

Banff, Yoho → Jasper Loop

3 BASE CAMPS

AUG 18 - 27, 2026 · CALGARY ROUND TRIP

BASE 01

Canmore, AB

Aug 18 - 21

3 Nights

Banff town · Lake Minnewanka ·
Lake Louise · Moraine Lake

BASE 02

Golden / Field, BC

Aug 21 - 23

2 Nights

Yoho NP · Emerald Lake · Takakkaw
Falls · Natural Bridge

BASE 03

Jasper, AB

Aug 23 - 27

4 Nights

Icefields Parkway · Maligne Lake ·
Pyramid Lake · Athabasca Falls

THE ROUTE

Calgary → Canmore → Yoho → Jasper → Calgary



DRIVING AT A GLANCE

LEG	KM	EST. TIME	HIGHWAY
Calgary YYC → Canmore	125 km	~1.5 hr	Hwy 2 N → Trans-Canada Hwy 1 W
Canmore → Golden / Field	130 km	1.5–2.5 hr + stops	Hwy 1 W through Lake Louise and Kicking Horse Pass
Golden / Field → Jasper	230–310 km	4.5–5 hr + stops	Hwy 1 E → Icefields Parkway / Hwy 93 N
Jasper → Calgary YYC	~410 km	~5 hr + stops	Hwy 93 S → Hwy 1 E → Hwy 2 S
Total loop distance	~900–1,000 km	~12–14 hr	Excludes local sightseeing mileage



TUESDAY, AUGUST 18, 2026

Calgary Arrival → Canmore

125 km • ~1.5 hr • Return rental YYC → YYC

● **Fly into Calgary YYC** Morning

Collect luggage and pick up the SUV rental at YYC. This is now a round-trip rental, so confirm the Calgary return location and keep the reservation simple.

● **Calgary grocery stop** ~30 min

Stock snacks, breakfast items, water, sunscreen, and trail food before heading west. Grocery options are easy in Canmore, but Calgary is the lowest-friction first stop.

● **Drive to Canmore** Afternoon

Take Hwy 2 north, then Trans-Canada Hwy 1 west. The first big mountain reveal comes as the Bow Valley opens near Canmore.

● **Check in + Canmore dinner** Evening

Settle into the first base. Walk Main Street, confirm shuttle and Pursuit reservations, and keep the first night easy.

BOOK BEFORE YOU GO

Prioritize Moraine Lake shuttle, Maligne Lake Cruise, Columbia Icefield, Banff Gondola, Lake Minnewanka Cruise, and all three lodging bases. August is peak season.

DAY

2

WEDNESDAY, AUGUST 19, 2026

Lake Louise + Moraine Lake

Canmore base • shuttle day • 2-3 hr total driving

- **Lake Louise Park & Ride**

Early morning

Drive to the Lake Louise Ski Resort Park & Ride and check in for your reserved Parks Canada shuttle. Use the connector to see both Lake Louise and Moraine Lake in one day.

- **Moraine Lake — Rockpile viewpoint**

Morning

Start with the Valley of Ten Peaks while light is clean and crowds are lower. Rockpile is the essential short walk; canoe rentals are optional if the line is reasonable.

- **Lake Louise lakeshore or Tea House hike**

Midday

For a lighter day, walk the lakeshore to Victoria Glacier views. For stronger hikers, Lake Agnes Tea House is the best upgrade.

- **Johnston Canyon on the return**

Late afternoon

If the group has energy, stop for the Lower and Upper Falls catwalk trail. If not, save Johnston Canyon as a flexible backup for Day 3.

MORAINE LAKE LOGISTICS

Personal vehicles are not permitted on Moraine Lake Road. Use Parks Canada shuttle, Roam transit, or a licensed commercial operator; reserve early and set an alarm for released seats.

DAY

3

THURSDAY, AUGUST 20, 2026

Banff Town + Lake Minnewanka

Local Banff loop • 2-3 hr total driving

- **Banff Gondola — Sulphur Mountain** Morning • Pursuit Pass

Ride to the summit boardwalk for the cleanest panoramic view of the Bow Valley. Book a morning slot and leave time for parking or shuttle logistics.

- **Banff Avenue + Bow Falls** Midday

Lunch in Banff, then walk to Bow Falls for an easy river viewpoint. This keeps the day scenic without overloading it after the lake day.

- **Lake Minnewanka Cruise or shoreline** Afternoon • Pursuit Pass option

Use the cruise if it is part of your pass and schedule; otherwise the shoreline viewpoint and Two Jack Lake drive are worthwhile on their own.

- **Pack for Yoho / Golden** Evening

Tomorrow crosses the Continental Divide. Confirm Golden or Field check-in and make sure fuel, snacks, and offline maps are set.

DAY

4

FRIDAY, AUGUST 21, 2026

Canmore → Yoho / Golden

130 km • 1.5–2.5 hr + scenic stops

- **Scenic drive over Kicking Horse Pass** Morning

Leave Canmore after breakfast and head west past Lake Louise into Yoho. The drive is short enough to make the transfer day feel like sightseeing, not a slog.

- **Spiral Tunnels viewpoint** Quick stop

Classic railway engineering stop on the Trans-Canada. Worth a short pullout if visibility is good and timing is easy.

- **Natural Bridge + Emerald Lake** Afternoon

Natural Bridge is a fast, high-value stop. Emerald Lake is the anchor: walk part of the shoreline, rent canoes if conditions are calm, and linger here.

- **Check into Golden / Field** Evening

Golden gives more lodging and food options; Field is quieter and closer to Yoho. Either works as long as Day 5 stays local.

DAY

SATURDAY, AUGUST 22, 2026

5

Yoho National Park

Golden / Field base • 2-3 hr total driving

- **Takakkaw Falls** Morning • seasonal road

One of the signature waterfall stops in the Rockies. The access road is seasonal and winding, so check current conditions before committing the morning.

- **Emerald Lake second pass or Iceline trail** Midday

Keep the default easy: more Emerald Lake time, lunch, and short walks. If the group wants a serious hiking day, choose an Iceline segment instead.

- **Wapta Falls or Golden Skybridge** Afternoon

Wapta Falls is the nature-forward pick. Golden Skybridge is the Pursuit-style paid attraction option if the group wants something structured.

- **Early night before Jasper transfer** Evening

Tomorrow is the biggest scenery day of the trip. Fuel up, pack the car plan, and confirm Columbia Icefield reservation timing.

WHY KEEP YOHO

This is the only BC base, but it is efficient: Emerald Lake, Natural Bridge, Takakkaw Falls, and Golden are clustered close to the Alberta border.

DAY

6

SUNDAY, AUGUST 23, 2026

Yoho / Golden → Jasper

Icefields Parkway • 4.5-5 hr driving + stops

- **Bow Lake + Peyto Lake** Morning

Return east to Lake Louise, then turn north onto the Icefields Parkway. Bow Lake is the first easy shoreline stop; Peyto Lake is the quick high-reward viewpoint.

- **Columbia Icefield Adventure + Skywalk** Midday • Pursuit Pass

Time the reservation so the day does not get rushed. This is the best place to use the bigger-ticket Pursuit attraction on the transfer north.

- **Sunwapta Falls + Athabasca Falls** Afternoon

Both are natural breaks on the final run into Jasper. If time gets tight, prioritize Athabasca Falls for the shortest, strongest stop.

- **Arrive Jasper, check in** Evening

Settle into the longest base. Keep dinner simple and avoid scheduling another major activity after the Parkway day.

JASPER 2026 REALITY CHECK

Maligne Canyon and Edith Cavell are not reliable for this itinerary because Parks Canada lists them closed for the 2026 season. This plan uses Maligne Lake, Medicine Lake, Pyramid Lake, waterfalls, and the townsite instead.

DAYS

7-9

MONDAY-WEDNESDAY, AUGUST 24-26, 2026

Jasper National Park

Three local days · lakes, waterfalls, wildlife, rest time

AUG 24 — MALIGNE ROAD

- **Medicine Lake viewpoint** Morning

Drive Maligne Road slowly and watch for wildlife. Medicine Lake is the best low-effort stop before continuing to Maligne Lake.

- **Maligne Lake Cruise**

Book ahead · Pursuit Pass option

Use this as the anchor for the Jasper stay. Spirit Island is the postcard view, and the drive itself is part of the experience.

- **Jasper town dinner** Evening

Keep the evening light after the longer lake road. Walk Connaught Drive and watch for elk around town.

AUG 25-26 — FLEXIBLE JASPER DAYS

- **Pyramid Lake + Patricia Lake** Half day

Easy, beautiful, and close to town. Walk Pyramid Island, rent paddles if conditions are calm, or keep it as a recovery morning.

- **Jasper SkyTram or Miette Hot Springs**

Choose one

SkyTram is the view-focused option if running and included in your package. Miette is the softer recovery day if the group wants a break.

- **Athabasca River valley + stargazing**

Evening

Use clear nights for dark-sky viewing. Jasper is at its best when the itinerary leaves room for weather, wildlife, and slower moments.

WHY FOUR JASPER NIGHTS

The reference compresses Jasper slightly. Four nights works better because Day 6 is mostly the Icefields Parkway, then Days 7–9 give three real Jasper days before the long return to Calgary.

DAY

10

THURSDAY, AUGUST 27, 2026

Jasper → Calgary → Fly Out

~410 km • ~5 hr + stops • Return SUV at YYC

- **Early departure from Jasper**

Morning

Treat this as a travel day with scenery, not a full sightseeing day. Start early enough to protect flight timing and rental return.

- **Icefields Parkway southbound stops**

Flexible

Use this direction for anything missed on Day 6: Waterfowl Lakes, Saskatchewan River Crossing, Bow Lake, or a second Peyto Lake stop.

- **Calgary airport return**

Per flight schedule

Return the SUV at YYC. For an evening flight, target Calgary with a generous buffer; summer rental returns and airport lines can still run long.

FLIGHT TIMING

A late afternoon or evening departure is much more comfortable. A morning flight would require driving back to Calgary the prior night.

QUICK REFERENCE

Must-See Highlights + Trip Tips

Moraine Lake

Valley of Ten Peaks, accessed by shuttle or licensed operator. This is the most

Lake Louise

Pair the lakeshore with Moraine Lake, or upgrade to Lake Agnes Tea House if the group wants a moderate hike.

Emerald Lake

The Yoho anchor. Less urban than Banff, easier to linger, and a strong reason to keep the Golden / Field base.

important reservation in the Banff portion.

Takakkaw Falls

High-impact waterfall stop in Yoho. Check seasonal road status before relying on it for the day.

Columbia Icefield

The best transfer-day anchor between Yoho and Jasper: glacier, Skywalk, and huge Icefields Parkway scenery.

Maligne Lake

Jasper's signature lake day. Book the cruise ahead and use Medicine Lake as the natural stop on the way.

PARK ADMISSION

Your dates fall inside Parks Canada's 2026 free-admission window, but shuttle tickets, paid parking, tours, and attraction reservations still need to be booked separately.

PURSUIT PASS COVERAGE

Confirm the exact 2026 package. Likely candidates: Banff Gondola, Lake Minnewanka Cruise, Columbia Icefield, Maligne Lake Cruise, and Golden Skybridge.

JASPER CLOSURES

Do not build the plan around Maligne Canyon or Edith Cavell for 2026. Parks Canada lists those areas closed while recovery work continues.

PRE-TRIP BOOKING CHECKLIST

Moraine Lake shuttle · Maligne Lake Cruise · Columbia Icefield · Banff Gondola · Lake Minnewanka Cruise · three lodging bases · YYC round-trip SUV.

AUGUST WEATHER + PACKING

Warm days, cool nights, fast weather changes. Pack shell jackets, layers, sunscreen, water bottles, bug spray, and footwear that can handle wet trails.

DRIVING + FUEL NOTES

Top off in Canmore, Golden, and Jasper. Keep offline maps for Yoho, Icefields Parkway, Maligne Road, and the Jasper-to-Calgary return.